

Review

P450s in plant–insect interactions

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ABSTRACT

Cytochrome P450 monooxygenases (P450s) are integral in defining the relationships between plants and insects. Secondary metabolites produced in plants for protection against insects and other organisms are synthesized via pathways that include P450s in many different families and subfamilies. Survival of insects in the presence of toxic secondary metabolites depends on their metabolism by more limited groups of P450s. Examples of functionally characterized plant and insect P450s known to be involved in these interactions are discussed in terms of their diversities, reactivities and regulators. These and future examples, which will be uncovered as the fields of plant biology and entomology converge on this interesting area, provide much insight into the array of plant metabolites that are mainline defenses against insects, the range of insect monooxygenases that inactivate these compounds and the evolutionary processes occurring as these organisms wage daily battles with one another. Molecular perspectives on these interactions will provide the scientific community with information critical for genetic manipulation of these organisms aimed at enhancing plant resistance to insects and eliminating insect resistance to natural plant toxins and synthetic insecticides.

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1. Introduction

P450s have long been recognized as exceptionally unusual in their ability to mediate the complex insertions of molecular oxygen into different substrates. It is only now becoming evident through genomic sequencing efforts that the number and range of P450s within an individual organism reflect, to some extent, its lifestyle and its mode of defense against toxins in its environment. Plants and herbivorous insects provide especially interesting examples of this relationship as they wage a continuing battle with one another – with one being a stationary food source and the other being an exploratory consumer of plant components. Success of the first (plants) depends on production of an array of toxic defense compounds fending off the second (insects). Success of the second depends on inactivation and/or evasion of the most detrimental toxins.

As plants and insects have evolved in their ecological interactions and biochemical systems, P450 gene numbers have increased much more dramatically in plant genomes than in insect and vertebrate genomes. Examples of the many plant pathways that have evolved for producing ecologically important secondary metabolites as defenses against insect consumers are detailed later in this article but even these do not begin to do justice to complexities of plant secondary products. The evolution of these complex pathways has often necessitated that stereo- and regio-specific P450s be recruited for the biochemical processing and production of oxygenated intermediates. Frequently, expansions in

these biochemical capacities have arisen from cycles of duplication and divergence of reiterated gene copies and resulted in many substrate-selective P450s in each pathway and correspondingly large numbers of genes in plant genomes. Less frequently, the evolution of these pathways has caused substrate-processive P450s mediating multiple conversions on the same substrate to be included in each pathway. Examples of the insect systems that have evolved to counter the toxic effects of these plant metabolites indicate that evolution of detoxicative enzymes has often occurred by selective mutation of catalytic sites in existing or recently duplicated P450s (which alters substrate range) and/or by substantial mutation of promoter sequences (which enhances expression) and resulted in the maintenance of smaller numbers of genes in insect genomes. Taking into account these different molecular modes of adapting to ecological pressures, this review attempts to highlight our current knowledge of P450s relevant to plant–insect interactions and leaves to other reviews those involved in plant–fungal and plant–bacterial interactions. Recent general reviews on plant P450s include Werck-Reichhart et al. [1], Nielsen and Møller [2], Schuler et al. [3] and Mizutani and Ohta [4]. Recent general reviews on insect P450s include Feyereisen [5], Li et al. [6] and Despres et al. [7]. The diversity of plant secondary products is extensively summarized in Seigler [8] and Wink [9].

2. Plant P450s

2.1. Biosynthetic pathways

With plant P450s generally mediating the same sorts of aliphatic hydroxylations, aromatic hydroxylations, epoxidations, isomerizations, dimerizations, carbon–carbon cleavages, carboxylations and other reactions commonly attributed to mammalian P450s, many

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have been recruited to highly specialized functions as plants have evolved new pathways for the production of defense toxins. The most conservative estimates suggest that the 300,000 plant species existing in the world collectively generate over 200,000 natural products [10]. Acknowledging that these numbers are likely to increase as metabolomic profilings reveal the complexities of individual plant pathways, it is clear that P450s have key and often rate-limiting roles in the production of plant allelochemicals.

Among these, terpenoids represent one of the largest classes of plant defense compounds (more than 40,000 structures) that includes toxic and repellent ecological defense compounds (e.g., limonene, perillyl alcohol, citral, myrcene, and pinenes) [11,12]. Alkaloids represent another large and extremely diverse class of plant defense compounds (more than 12,000 structures) that include the pharmaceutically relevant isoquinoline and benzyloquinoline alkaloids (berbamunine, tubocurarine, morphine, and codeine), monoterpene indole alkaloids (vinblastine, vincristine, quinine, and strychnine), tropane and nicotine alkaloids (nicotine, scopolamine, and atropine), purine alkaloids (caffeine) and alkaloid esters (homoharringtonine) [13–15].

Smaller classes of plant defense compounds also exist. Among the most toxic of these, furanocoumarins (more than 200 structures) are derived by attachment of a furan ring to coumarin in either a linear orientation (xanthotoxin, bergapten, and psoralen) or an angular orientation (angelicin and sphondin) (Fig. 1A) [16–18]. Like their structural furanochromone (visnagin and khellin) relatives, furanocoumarins are phototoxic to a variety of organisms and cell types as a result of their ability to crosslink DNA [18,19]. Glucosinolates (more than 120 structures) are thioglucosides derived from methionine (aliphatic glucosinolates), tryptophan (indole glucosinolates) and phenylalanine (benzylglucosinolates) (Fig. 2) [20,21]. Piperamides (piperidine, piperine, and piperidine), which serve as natural insecticides, are derived from the linkage of amides and methylenedioxyphenyl (MDP) moieties [22]. Benzoxazinoids (DIMBOA) are hydroxamic acids derived from indole [23]. Cyanogenic glucosides (dhurrin) are derived from tyrosine and converted to toxic cyanide by β -glucosidases and hydroxyl nitrile lyases released in insect-damaged plants [24,25].

In addition to these chemically distinct categories, many plant allelochemicals are derived from the phenylpropanoid pathway. Among these, the simplest MDP compounds (myristicin, sesamin, and safrole) are dimeric phenylpropanoids that, like the synthetic piperonyl butoxide (PBO), interfere with P450 activities in a wide range of organisms including insects and mammals [26,27]. Flavonoids (flavone, quercetin, and genistein) are monomeric phenylpropanoids that can also interfere with P450 activities and, at some concentrations and cellular conditions, can act as antioxidants [28–31]. Contrasting with the detrimental effects of these previously mentioned phenylpropanoids, anthocyanins derived from another branch in the phenylpropanoid pathway serve as floral pigments and attractants to insect pollinators [30,32]. Stilbenes (resveratrol, piceatannol, and viniferins) derived from yet another branch have been reported to enhance longevity in *Drosophila* and other metazoans [33,34].

Because insects constantly subjected to these types of defense toxins readily develop resistance against one or more of them, plants contain suites of allelochemicals that can be used in their chemical defense. Some plants contain a wide array of moderately toxic defense compounds while others contain only a small number of highly toxic defense compounds. Furanocoumarins, which occur with various structures in the Apiaceae, provide good examples of the effectiveness of combinatorial mixtures: tested individually, many have detrimental effects on insect growth and development and, tested in mixtures, their chemical combinations are significantly more toxic [35].

2.2. Gene counts and organizations

P450 gene duplications and divergences occurring in the evolutionary process have resulted in astounding numbers of P450 genes in

higher plants. In sequenced plant genomes, the P450 gene superfamily includes 245 full-length genes in *Arabidopsis thaliana* (mouse ear's cress), 332 in *Oryza sativa* (rice), 315 in *Vitis vinifera* (grape), 310 in *Populus trichocarpa* (poplar) and 142 in *Carica papaya* (papaya) [1,36–41]. Evolutionary tours of these five plant genomes typically show long clusters of genes within the same P450 subfamily with those in the same clade and related P450 families usually containing introns at common positions [37–39]. These clusters are frequently interspersed with more divergent genes from other P450 subfamilies, as seen in the CYP2ABFGST gene clusters in mammals. Acknowledging that these statements tend to oversimplify the relationships of plant P450 genes, it is the exceptions to them that highlight the high degree of genetic rearrangement in plant genomes and the complexity of P450 evolution in plants. Exceptions occurring in *Arabidopsis* include the CYP71B subfamily (which contains 35 members tandemly arrayed at eight locations among all five of its chromosomes), the large CYP71 and CYP705 families (whose members contain from 0 to 7 introns) and the small CYP96A subfamily (whose members contain 0–3 introns) [3,36].

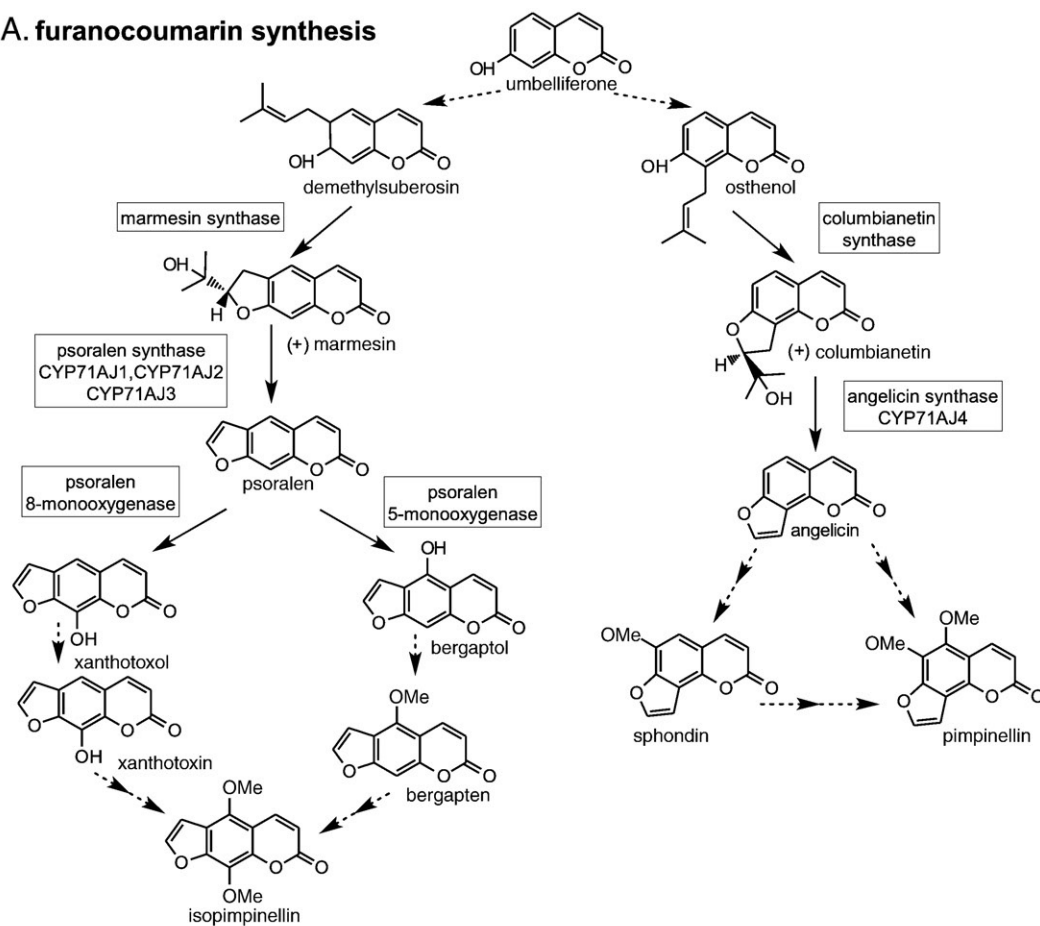
2.3. P450s in biosynthetic pathways

Among the many plant P450s, relatively few families and subfamilies have been maintained in all sequenced plant genomes. Families existing in *Physcomitrella patens* (moss) and the five higher plants include CYP51 mediating obtusifol 14 α -demethylation, CYP74 mediating oxylipin synthesis (jasmonic acid and methyl jasmonate) and catabolism (C_6 -volatiles), CYP86, CYP94, CYP703 and CYP704 mediating various fatty acid hydroxylations, CYP97 mediating various carotenoid hydroxylations and CYP701 mediating multiple conversions in gibberellin synthesis [4,39]. Subfamilies existing in these six genomes include CYP73A mediating cinnamic acid hydroxylation in early phenylpropanoid synthesis, CYP78A mediating an unspecified conversion controlling organ development, CYP98A mediating shikimate hydroxylation in the lignin branch of phenylpropanoid metabolism and CYP710A mediating sterol C22-desaturations. Without moss included in these comparisons, families existing in the five higher plants include, CYP85 and CYP90 mediating multiple steps in brassinosteroid synthesis. Subfamilies existing in these higher plants include CYP75B mediating flavonoid hydroxylation, CYP84A mediating ferulate hydroxylation, CYP88A mediating additional conversions in gibberellin synthesis, CYP77A mediating fatty acid hydroxylations, CYP707A mediating abscisic acid (sesquiterpene) catabolism, CYP711A mediating strictolactone (terpenoid lactone) synthesis, CYP734A mediating brassinosteroid catabolism, CYP735A mediating cytokinin catabolism and CYP72A, CYP77B and CYP87A with as-yet-undefined functions [4,39].

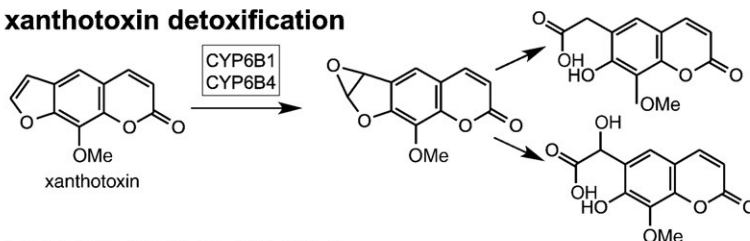
Apart from these families and subfamilies that are conserved for common functions in plant development and environmental response, the P450 subfamilies involved in allelochemical production occur in more limited groups of plants because of differences in the range of their secondary metabolites, the substrate specificities of their monooxygenases, the existence of alternate enzymes mediating similar reactions and, sometimes, differences in their physiological processes. In the Brassicaceae such as *Arabidopsis thaliana*, aliphatic glucosinolate synthesis (Fig. 2A) is mediated by CYP79F1 and CYP79F2, each of which has distinct functions in the conversion of short- and long-chain methionine derivatives to oximes [42–44], prior to their modification by CYP83A1 [45–47]. Indole glucosinolate synthesis (Fig. 2B) is mediated by CYP79B2 and CYP79B3, each of which functions in the conversion of tryptophan derivatives to indole-3-acetylloxime [48,49], prior to its oxidation by CYP83B1 [45,47,50]. Benzylglucosinolate synthesis is mediated by CYP79A2, which mediates the conversion of phenylalanine to oxime [51], prior to its oxidation by CYP83B1, the convergence point for benzylglucosinolate and indole glucosinolate syntheses.

In *Sorghum bicolor* (sorghum), synthesis of the cyanogenic glucoside dhurrin is mediated by the sequential N-hydroxylation of tyrosine,

A. furanocoumarin synthesis



B. xanthotoxin detoxification



C. imperatorin detoxification

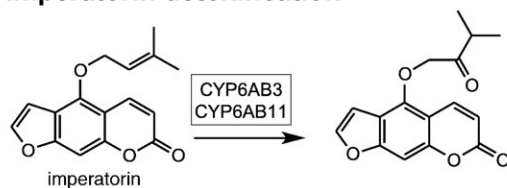


Fig. 1. Furanocoumarin synthesis and degradation. (A) The synthetic pathway for linear (left branch) and angular (right branch) furanocoumarins occurring in some umbelliferous plants is shown with boxes designating known P450 steps. (B) P450 detoxification of the linear furanocoumarin xanthotoxin occurring in some lepidopteran insects (*Papilio polyxenes*, *P. glaucus*, *Helicoverpa zea* and others) occurs via epoxidation on the furan ring and subsequent hydroxylation. (C) P450 detoxification of the linear furanocoumarin imperatorin occurring in some lepidopteran insects (*Depressaria pastinacella*, *Amyelois transitella*) occurs via epoxidation of the extended isoprenyl side chain.

dehydration and decarboxylation to *p*-hydroxyphenyl aldoxime by the multifunctional CYP79A1 [52,53]. This intermediate is subsequently dehydrated and hydroxylated to cyanohydrin *p*-hydroxymandelonitrile by the multifunctional CYP71E1 [54]. Orthologues of CYP79A1, which have been identified in a number of cyanogenic dicots and monocots [55–58], include CYP79D subfamily members in *Manihot esculenta* (cassava) and *Lotus japonicus* (trefoil) that are involved in the synthesis of linamarin and lotaustralin (cyanoalk(en)yl glycosides) from valine

and isoleucine. Orthologues of CYP71E1 are not readily apparent in any of the sequenced plant genomes.

As suggested by the numerous defense toxins derived from the phenylpropanoid pathway and the presence of CYP73A subfamily members in all plants, *p*-hydroxylation of *t*-cinnamic acid to produce *p*-coumaric acid is an early P450-mediated conversion essential to all plants. In the Apiaceae, which includes *Pastinaca sativa* (parsnip), *Ammi majus* (Bishop's weed) and *Apium graveolens* (celery), as well as

A. aliphatic glucosinolate synthesis B. indole glucosinolate synthesis

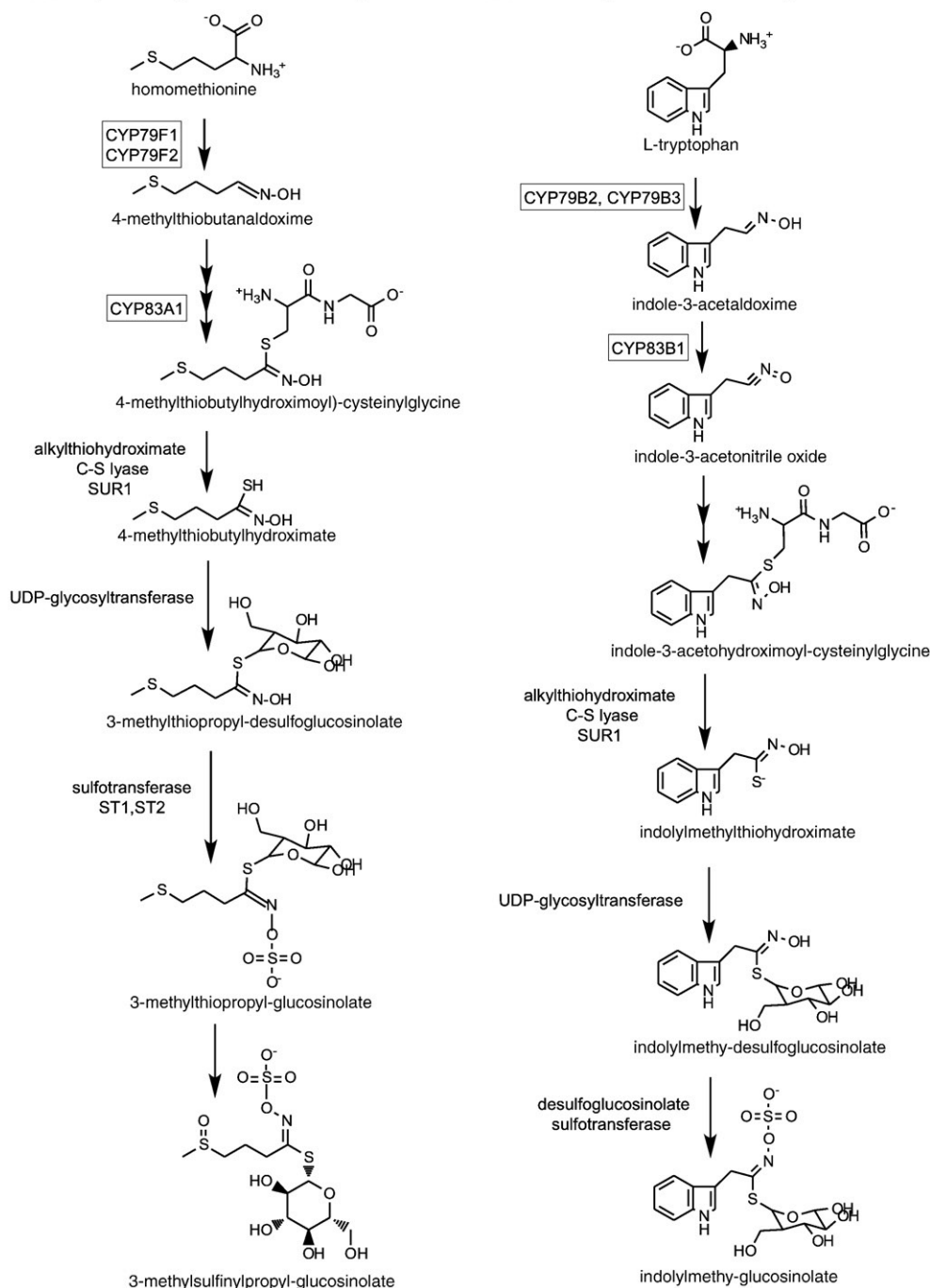


Fig. 2. Glucosinolate synthesis. The synthetic pathways for (A) aliphatic glucosinolates and (B) indole glucosinolates occurring in *Arabidopsis thaliana* are shown with boxes designating known P450 steps.

selected species of Rutaceae, Fabaceae and Moraceae, production of coumarins proceeds via the P450-mediated *o*-hydroxylation of *p*-coumaric acid to generate 2,4-dihydroxycinnamic acid and then to umbelliferone [59]. Subsequent modifications by prenyltransferases acting at alternate positions bifurcate the furanocoumarin pathway (Fig. 1A) to produce demethylsuberosin, the precursor for linear furanocoumarins, and osthenol, the precursor for angular furanocoumarins. Conversion of the 6-prenylated substrate to marmesin is mediated by an unidentified P450 and linear furanocoumarin synthesis proceeds using psoralen synthases (CYP71AJ1, CYP71AJ2,

and CYP71AJ3) and O-methyltransferases [59–61]. Conversion of the 8-prenylated substrate to columbianetin is mediated by another unidentified P450 and angular furanocoumarin synthesis proceeds using a closely related angelicin synthase (CYP71AJ4). With obvious phylogenetic origins and relatively high overall amino acid identity (70–90%), these psoralen synthases and angelicin synthase mediate quite different catalytic reactions (formation of a dihydrofuran ring from a prenylated substrate vs. oxidative carbon–carbon chain cleavage) because of significant differences in four of their substrate recognition sites (SRS2, SRS3, SRS4, and SRS6) [61]. Once formed,

psoralen and angelicin are further hydroxylated at several positions on the coumarin nucleus by other unidentified P450s yielding the wide array of complex linear and angular furanocoumarins (xanthotoxin, bergapten, and sphondin) present in the Apiaceae, Rutaceae and Fabaceae [59].

In *Sesame indicum* (sesame), the dimerization of the phenylpropanoid derivative pinoresinol to form the furofuran lignan sesamin containing two methylenedioxy bridges is mediated by CYP81Q1 [62]. Pinoresinol, which is itself formed by the coupling of conferyl alcohols, is also converted into sesamin by the related CYP81Q2 from *S. radiatum* (96% identical to CYP81Q1) but not by CYP81Q3 from *S. alatum*; divergences in the SRS2 and SRS3 regions of CYP81Q3 may account for these catalytic deficiencies. No other P450s involved in the synthesis of furofuran lignans have yet been cloned making it unclear whether they are members of this same subfamily. Those involved in the formation of methylenedioxy bridges in other groups of compounds, such as antimicrobial alkaloids, are categorized in an entirely different group of P450s. In *Coptis japonica* (Japanese goldthread), this includes CYP719A1 that mediates methylenedioxy bridge formation in berberine synthesis [63]. In *Eschscholzia californica* (California poppy), this includes several CYP719A subfamily members that mediate methylenedioxy bridge formation in stylophine synthesis and eventually lead to sanguinarine and macarpine synthesis [64,65]. Among these, CYP719A1 is 65% identical to CYP719A2 and CYP719A3 and just 24% amino acid identical to CYP81Q1 in furofuran lignan synthesis. P450s involved in other methylenedioxy bridge formations have not yet been identified.

In Coniferales (conifers), P450s involved in synthesizing and modifying complex mixtures of monoterpenes (myrcene, pinenes), sesquiterpenes (farnesene) and diterpenes (abietadienol and abietic acid) provide especially interesting perspectives on the chemical ecologies associated with plant–insect interactions. Conversion of geranylgeranyl diphosphate to C₂₀ terpenoid skeletons, such as abietadiene and cadinene, by terpenoid synthases [66] is followed by multiple oxidation steps generating diterpenoid resin acids [12]. The multifunctional CYP720B1 and close relatives in this subfamily are capable of utilizing diterpenes, alcohols and aldehydes as substrates to produce large collections of diterpene olefins, alcohols, aldehydes and resin acids [67–69].

In *Zea mays* (maize), a series of four clustered P450 genes in the CYP71C subfamily synthesize benzoxazinoids such as DIMBOA that is broken down to toxic aglycons upon herbivore damage [70–72]. The fact that several other monocots and dicots synthesize benzoxazinoids indicates that this biosynthetic pathway has evolved independently several times [73] but the P450 complements mediating these other synthetic reactions have not yet cloned.

2.4. P450s in defense signaling pathways

Biosyntheses of these plant defense toxins are often dramatically activated by signaling pathways that also include P450s. Some of their most effective inducers, jasmonate (JA) and methyl jasmonate (MeJA), are cyclic oxidation products derived from linolenic acid via allene oxide synthases, which are unconventional P450s in the CYP74A subfamily [74,75]. Other inducers, including hexenal, related C₆-volatiles and octadecanoic acid, are cleavage products derived from the same polyunsaturated fatty acid via hydroperoxide lyases, which are in the CYP74B subfamily [76,77].

3. Insect P450s

3.1. Gene counts

Insects have clearly adapted to the presence of plant toxins in their diets. Among several enzyme groups capable of inactivating plant toxins, P450s are key mediators of the hydroxylations and epoxidations required for the efficient destruction and elimination of toxins

prior to their adsorption in gut tissues. In insect genomes that have not undergone the level of gene duplication seen in plant genomes, the P450 gene superfamily includes 46 full-length genes in *Apis mellifera* (honey bee), 87 in *Drosophila melanogaster* (fruit fly), 83 in *D. pseudoobscura*, 105 in *Anopheles gambiae* (malarial mosquito), 153 in *Aedes aegypti* (dengue and yellow fever mosquito), 79 in *Bombyx mori* (silkworm), 91 in *Nasonia vitripennis* (parasitoid wasp) and 136 in *Tribolium castaneum* (red flour beetle) [41,78–82]. These and other sequences cloned more sporadically account for the current total of 1750 insect P450 sequences available in databases.

3.2. P450s in detoxicative pathways

Despite their critical importance in defining food sources for herbivores, the P450s responsible for the metabolism of plant allelochemicals have been studied in only a few insect species [5–7,83,84]. Those involved in the biotransformation of toxic plant furanocoumarins have been characterized in eight insect species (four *Papilio* species (swallowtails), *Helicoverpa zea* (corn earworm), *Depressaria pastinacella* (parsnip webworm), *Amyelois transitella* (navel orangeworm) and *A. gambiae*). In the specialist *P. polyxenes*, CYP6B1 metabolizes several, but not all, linear furanocoumarins efficiently (Fig. 1B) and angular furanocoumarins when supplemented with additional P450 reductase [85–89]. In the related generalists *P. glaucus* and *P. multicaudatus* that encounter wider ranges of toxins in their host plants, CYP6B4, CYP6B17 and CYP6B33 metabolize a broad range of linear and angular furanocoumarins [85,90–92].

In the generalist *H. zea*, multiple CYP6B subfamily members exist [93,94]. Of these, CYP6B8 metabolizes xanthotoxin (similar to *Papilio* CYP6B1, CYP6B4 and CYP6B33) as well as a variety of other plant compounds (flavone, α -naphthoflavone (α -NF), chlorogenic acid, indole-3-carbinol, quercetin, and rutin) and insecticides (cypermethrin (pyrethroid), diazinon (organophosphate), and aldrin (cyclodiene)) [95,96]. The predicted structures for the closely related CYP6B9 and CYP6B27 suggest that their substrate specificities are very similar to those determined for CYP6B8. In addition, *H. zea* also expresses CYP321A1, which metabolizes many of the same compounds as CYP6B8 (xanthotoxin, angelicin, α -NF, cypermethrin, diazinon, and aldrin) and an additional fungal toxin (aflatoxin B1) [96–98]. The existence of two different groups of P450s mediating similar metabolisms indicates that these allelochemical detoxification systems have evolved at least twice in these species.

In the highly specialized *D. pastinacella* that feeds solely on two furanocoumarin-containing plants and metabolizes furanocoumarins at very high rates (10-fold higher than any *Papilio* species) [99], CYP6AB3 selectively metabolizes one furanocoumarin (imperatorin) (Fig. 1C) and one natural MDP compound (myristicin), which are extremely abundant in its host plants [100–102]. With just these two demonstrated activities and no ability to metabolize other furanocoumarins, CYP6AB3 is probably the most specialized P450 that can catabolize plant toxins. In *Amyelois transitella* (navel orangeworm) that devastates almond, fig and pistachio nuts, a closely related CYP6AB11 also metabolizes significant amounts of imperatorin but not myristicin [103]. Reflecting the high diversity of P450s metabolizing furanocoumarins: *D. pastinacella* CYP6AB3 shares 55% amino acid identity with *A. transitella* CYP6AB11 and 36–38% identity with members of the CYP6B subfamily; *A. transitella* CYP6AB11 shares 35–38% identity with the CYP6B subfamily, 55% identity with *D. pastinacella* CYP6AB3 and 67% identity with *B. mori* CYP6AB4; *H. zea* CYP321A1 shares 30–32% amino acid identity with members of the CYP6B subfamily. Additional CYP6B subfamily members identified in *D. pastinacella* and *A. transitella* have not yet been demonstrated to metabolize furanocoumarins.

Other biochemically characterized insect P450s capable of metabolizing plant allelochemicals include *M. domestica* CYP6A1 that metabolizes plant terpenoids [104], *Diploptera punctata* (Pacific beetle

cockroach) CYP4C7 that hydroxylates juvenile hormone III (JHIII) and other sesquiterpenoids [105], *A. mellifera* CYP6AS members that metabolize quercetin (flavonoid) [106], *A. gambiae* CYP6Z1 that metabolizes furanocoumarins (xanthotoxin and bergapten), furanochromones (khellin and visnagin) and natural MDP compounds (myristicin, safrole and isosafrole) [107,108], *A. gambiae* CYP6Z2 that metabolizes xanthotoxin, enterodiol (lignan), resveratrol and piceatannol (stilbenes) [109].

In addition to these examples, P450s in various Coleoptera species including *Ips pini* (pine engraver beetles) and *Ips paraconfusus* (California five-spined ips) have evolved fairly novel strategies for dealing with the especially high concentrations of monoterpenes, sesquiterpenes and diterpenoid resin acids encountered in their feeding and reproductive cycles, which occur in conifer barks. In addition to the expected P450-mediated detoxification of the monoterpene myrcene (by an unidentified P450), male bark beetles ingesting this monoterpene can use it as substrate for production of aggregation pheromone, a mixture of ipsdienol, ipsenol and other compounds that recruits other beetles to damaged trees and enhances the reproductive success of individual *Ips* species [110]. Not entirely willing to rely on exposure to plant-derived myrcene, male bark beetles synthesize myrcene *de novo* and then convert it into ipsdienol and ipsenol [110]. Molecular analysis of the *I. paraconfusus* P450 transcripts induced in response to pine bark mixtures identified several inducible CYP4 family members and one CYP9T subfamily member that are differentially expressed in males and females or else constitutively expressed in both sexes [111]. Similar analysis of *I. pini* P450 transcripts identified a closely related CYP9T subfamily member that is differentially expressed in males [112]. Biochemical characterizations of the *I. pini* CYP9T2 and *I. paraconfusus* CYP9T1 proteins subsequently indicated that, while both mediate production of ipsdienol racemers, the final proportions of these in various aggregation pheromone components are dictated by later enzymes in their metabolic pathways and not by either of these P450s [112,113]. Similar transcript analysis in *Dendroctonus ponderosae* (mountain pine beetle) has now identified CYP6CR1 as male-specific and inducible and implicated it in the production of this insect's male aggregation pheromone component, *exo*-brevicomin [114]. Although not yet biochemically characterized, it is suggested that CYP6CR1 mediates the epoxidation of a fatty acid precursor to 6,7-epoxynonan-2-one and that another unidentified P450 mediates hydroxylation of ingested α -pinene to verbenol.

In several cases, less direct evidence has implicated particular P450s in the metabolism of plant allelochemicals. In one recent example, transgenic plant-mediated RNAi silencing of *H. armigera* CYP6AE14 transcripts reduced larval tolerance to the sesquiterpene gossypol [115]. In other examples, inductions of CYP4D and CYP28A subfamily transcripts in cactophilic *Drosophila* species (*D. metterli*, *D. mojavensis*, *D. pachea* and *D. nigrospiracula*) exposed to toxic isoquinoline alkaloids have suggested that these particular P450s catabolize these compounds [116–118]. While differentially expressed by the isoquinoline alkaloids in their cactus hosts [117,118], phylogenetic analyses of the CYP28A1 and CYP4D10 genes have indicated that only the CYP28A1 sequence has adaptively evolved [119]. In the last example, inductions of CYP6A8, CYP6D5, CYP6W1, CYP9B2 and CYP12D1 transcripts in *D. melanogaster* exposed to *Piper nigrum* (black pepper) extracts have suggested that one or more of these are involved in catabolism of piperamides [120]. It is also possible that some of these proteins metabolize the assortment of MDP compounds present along with piperamides in *Piper* species.

3.3. Induction of detoxicative P450s

As noted previously, ingestion of plant toxins frequently causes insects to induce P450 transcripts responsible for catabolism of plant toxins, a feed-forward loop important for optimal survival as toxins are encountered in new plant groups. In the specialist *P. polyxenes*, CYP6B1 transcripts, which code for furanocoumarin metabolism, are

induced by the linear furanocoumarin xanthotoxin and to a lesser extent by the angular furanocoumarin angelicin [121–123]. Related CYP6B3 transcripts, which also code for furanocoumarin metabolism, are induced by a wide range of linear and angular furanocoumarins [123,124] providing these species with a broad inducible response to these group of toxins. In the generalist *H. zea*, CYP6B8 transcripts, which code for detoxification of a broad range of substrates, are strongly induced by xanthotoxin and imperatorin (furanocoumarins), indole-3-carbinol, chlorogenic acid (shikimate intermediate), flavone (flavone aglycone), jasmonic acid and salicylic acid (plant signaling molecules) and more weakly by gossypol (sesquiterpene), rutin (flavonol glycoside), visnagin (furanochromone), coumarin and quercetin (flavonol aglycone) [125–128]. CYP321A1 transcripts, which also code for detoxification of a broad range of substrates, are also induced by many of these same allelochemicals [97,127,128]. In the closely related *H. armigera*, CYP9A subfamily transcripts are induced by gossypol, deltamethrin (pyrethroid) and phenobarbital (PB, barbiturate drug); other plant xenobiotics have not been tested [129]. Consistent with their suggested involvement in gossypol metabolism, *H. armigera* CYP6AE14 transcripts are selectively induced by gossypol but not any terpenes or phenolics tested [115]. In the Solanaceae specialist *Manduca sexta* (tobacco hornworm), CYP6M and CYP9A subfamily transcripts are induced by 2-undecanone and 2-tridecanone (aliphatic ketones), indole 3-carbinol and xanthotoxin [130,131]. In *D. melanogaster*, CYP6A2, CYP6A8 and multiple other P450 transcripts are induced by caffeine (xanthine alkaloid), PB and PBO [132–134]. In this same species, CYP6A8, CYP12D1 and several other P450 transcripts are induced by black pepper extracts [120]. In *A. aegypti*, multiple CYP4, CYP6 and CYP9 family transcripts are induced in response to the allelochemical combinations in leaf litter [135]. In *A. mellifera*, several CYP6AS subfamily transcripts are induced by honey extracts [136]. Other examples of plant allelochemicals inducing insect P450 transcripts are summarized in Feyereisen [5].

In addition to these previous examples, several studies focusing solely on environmental xenobiotics have identified a few other synthetic compounds capable of inducing insect P450 transcripts. In *A. aegypti*, fluoranthene (arylhydrocarbon), permethrin and temephos (insecticides) and atrazine (herbicide) induce various CYP6 and CYP9 subfamily transcripts [137,138]. In *D. melanogaster*, dichlorodiphenyl-trichloroethane (DDT) induces CYP12D1 transcripts [139]. In *M. domestica*, permethrin induces several CYP4 and CYP6 family transcripts [140].

3.4. Inhibition of detoxicative P450s

Given that insects are exposed to varying mixtures of these environmental xenobiotics and host plant allelochemicals, P450 transcriptional responses are inevitably complex. This complexity is further complicated by the fact that some compounds in these mixtures induce expression of detoxicative P450 transcripts while other compounds inhibit their enzymatic functions. These inhibitory effects are clearly evident in the prominent use of PBO, the synthetic MDP compound, as an insecticide synergist intended to block P450-mediated metabolism of insecticides [141]. They are also evident in the use of natural mixtures of plant compounds, such as the piperamides from *Piper* species, as synergists [142].

Detailed analyses of the range of natural plant compounds interfering with metabolism have been conducted in only a few studies with heterologously expressed insect P450 proteins. Among these, furanocoumarin metabolism by *P. polyxenes* CYP6B1 is inhibited by a range of compounds including coumarins, MDPs (myristicin, safrole, and isosafrole), furanochromones (visnagin and khellin), flavonoids (flavone and α -naphthoflavone), alkaloids (pilocarpine) [143,144]. Comparisons among these inhibition profiles have indicated that the three natural MDP compounds inhibit CYP6B1 more efficiently than synthetic PBO and provided the first concrete evidence that PBO does not block all insect

P450 activities [144]. Benzyloxyresorufin (model substrate) metabolism by *A. gambiae* CYP6Z2 is inhibited by xanthotoxin, α -naphthoflavone, quercetin (flavonol), resveratrol (stilbene), genistein (isoflavone) and cypermethrin (pyrethroid) [109].

3.5. Catalytic site evolution

While comparatively few insect P450s metabolizing plant allelochemicals have been studied, catalytic sites in some of these have been analyzed in enough detail to understand the evolutionary adaptations that have allowed some to acquire new metabolic capabilities for toxins. Comparisons between the catalytic site in *P. polyxenes* CYP6B1, which metabolizes a select number of furanocoumarins, and *H. zea* CYP6B8, which metabolizes a broad range of plant allelochemicals and insecticides, have indicated that multiple aromatic residues in SRS2, SRS5 and SRS6 of CYP6B1 are replaced by nonaromatic residues in CYP6B8 [95,96]. These and additional polar-to-nonpolar replacements in the hydrophilic cage surrounding the aromatic network responsible for substrate positioning in CYP6B1 [143] are apparently sufficient to enhance catalytic site flexibility in CYP6B8 and account for its metabolism of a wide range of plant compounds and insecticides [95,96]. Similarly, comparisons of the catalytic site in *P. polyxenes* CYP6B1 with those in *P. glaucus* CYP6B4 and *P. canadensis* CYP6B33, which metabolize broader ranges of substrates, have shown that replacements of large catalytic site residues with smaller ones increases catalytic site volumes enough to accommodate the wider range of allelochemicals ingested by these polyphagous species [90,91]. Comparisons of the catalytic sites in *A. gambiae* CYP6Z1, which metabolizes a range of allelochemical and insecticide classes, and CYP6Z2, which metabolizes only a few compounds, have indicated that as few as one or two catalytic site replacements in SRS2 and SRS4 account for the broader substrate range of CYP6Z1 [107].

4. Conclusions

In summary, synthesis of the large array of defense toxins and other secondary metabolites in plants is accomplished by an astounding number of P450 proteins that have been derived from continual duplication and divergence of ancestral genes. As further biochemical characterizations of these proteins places them in particular biosynthetic pathways, the many types of molecular events associated with the evolution of plant pathways for the production of new defense toxins should become more apparent than currently. Our existing knowledge of plant P450s has already indicated that: (1) many P450 families and subfamilies are being utilized for production of defense toxins, (2) divergence in catalytic site residues of duplicated P450 gene sets can lead to novel defense toxins and (3) selective transcription limits production of defense toxins to tissues and conditions in which they are most needed. Countering this trend of increasing chemical diversity in plant evolution, biochemical characterizations of insect P450s capable of allelochemical metabolism have already indicated that: (1) relatively few P450 families and subfamilies used for the elimination of defense toxins, (2) divergence in catalytic site residues in existing P450 genes can substantially broaden substrate range and (3) selective transcription limits production of detoxicative enzymes to conditions in which they are most needed. Future analyses of P450s involved in plant–insect interactions will undoubtedly expand on the few P450 examples cited in this review and begin to describe novel biosynthetic and detoxicative functions not yet characterized. Coupled with adequate information on the range of inducers and inhibitors for each, these studies will provide critical information needed for further genetic manipulation of plant species for the production of transgenic plants with enhanced resistance to insects and genetic manipulation of insect species for inactivation of the monooxygenase activities mediating allelochemical and insecticide detoxifications. Recognizing that the combined collection of plant and insect P450s far outnumbers those in other organisms and that many

molecular, biochemical and computational tools are available for their studies, the future is bright for students and faculty versed in the technologies needed to define and manipulate P450s.

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